recently reached fruition and had operated with a sensitivity that was remarkable compared to what one might have expected; Braginsky and others had invented a number of clever and promising ideas for huge future improvements; and I and others were just beginning to realize that gravitational waves might revolutionize our understanding of the Universe.

My enthusiasm and optimism drove me, one evening in November 1976, to wander the streets of Pasadena until late into the night, struggling with myself over whether to propose that Caltech create a project to detect gravitational waves. The arguments in favor were obvious: for science in general, the enormous intellectual payoff if the project succeeded; for Caltech, the opportunity to get in on the ground floor of an exciting new field; for me, the possibility to have a team of experimenters at my home institution with whom to interact, instead of relying primarily on Braginsky and his team on the other side of the world, and the possibility to play a more central role than I could commuting to Moscow (and thereby have more fun). The argument against was also obvious: The project would be risky; to succeed, it would require large resources from Caltech and the D.S. National Science Foundation and enormous time and energy from me and others; and after all that investment, it might fail. It was much more risky than Caltech's entry into radio astronomy twenty-three years earlier (Chapter 9).

After many hours of introspection, the lure of the payoffs won me over. And after several months studying the risks and payoffs, Caltech's physics and astronomy faculty and administration unanimously approved my proposal—subject to two conditions. We would have to find an outstanding experimental physicist to lead the project, and the project would have to be large enough and strong enough to have a good chance of success. This meant, we believed, much larger and stronger than Weber's effort at the University of Maryland or Braginsky's effort in Moscow or any of the other gravitational-wave efforts then under way.

The first step was finding a leader. I flew to Moscow to ask Braginsky's advice and feel him out about taking the post. My feeler tore him every which way. He was torn between the far better technology he would have in America and the greater craftsmanship of the technicians in Moscow (for example, intricate glassblowing was almost a lost art in America, but not in Moscow). He was torn between the need to build a project from scratch in America and the crazy impediments that the inefficient, bureaucracy-bound